treacherous so only one-way traffic was permitted following a 'gate' system controlled by the SFF. On reaching Chakrata, the military-restricted area is to the left, heavily forested and well laid out. To the right is the civil area, with barren hillsides and unplanned development. The contrast couldn't be starker.

On reaching Chakrata, I reported to the Commandant and was promoted to the rank of Lt Col. This Commandant was the first non-Parachute Regiment officer to be posted to this fully paratrooper force and he was very keen to prove himself. I took over charge from Lt Col MB Saxena of the Assam Regiment, a very meticulous officer who carried out the handing over in great detail, including the pitfalls and the issues he had faced. He did not hold anything back with that 'let the new guy stumble and learn' attitude. Of all the times I have taken over, I must say that this was the best handing over that I ever had. I had done a fair job of handing over my BM duties to my relief, but this was even better, making me resolve to do the same in every future assignment. This was all the more important because this was an altogether new field as far as I was concerned. As officers, we are drawn more to the 'G' side, the operations side, which is more glamorous. Even after the Staff course, everyone wants to be slotted into an operations billet. Even as the handing over progressed, I realized how important were the 'A' and 'Q' sides of the staff. The 'A' branch deals with all aspects related to manpower, discipline, welfare, pay, allowances and the like—basically all HR issues. The 'Q' branch deals with all issues relating to logistics, supplies of all kinds—rations, water, fuel, maintenance of assets, both movable and immovable, and running of essential services. Wars may or may not happen, but troops had to be housed and fed all year round. There was no 'off' day when it came to Q matters. Sunday or holiday, rain or shine, the maintenance chain had to keep running.

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